

COMPLETE UNIT

KS3: Early Modern World & Global Encounters (1450–1750)



COURSE TEXTBOOK

*Enquiry: How 'global' was Britain's transformation between
1450 and 1750?*

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L1: Who held global power in 1450?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the major global powers and trading hubs in the year 1450.
- ☐ Explain how the Ottoman Empire and West African kingdoms controlled global wealth.
- ☐ Evaluate why Western Europe was on the periphery (edges) of world trade in 1450.

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Select *THREE* terms that share a close historical connection. Identify which *ONE* remaining term is the 'Odd One Out' in this lesson, and explain your historical reasoning:

Ming Dynasty | Ottoman Empire | Songhai Empire | Silk Roads | Fall of Constantinople (1453) | Eurocentrism

Teacher Model / Pupil Reasoning:

Source A



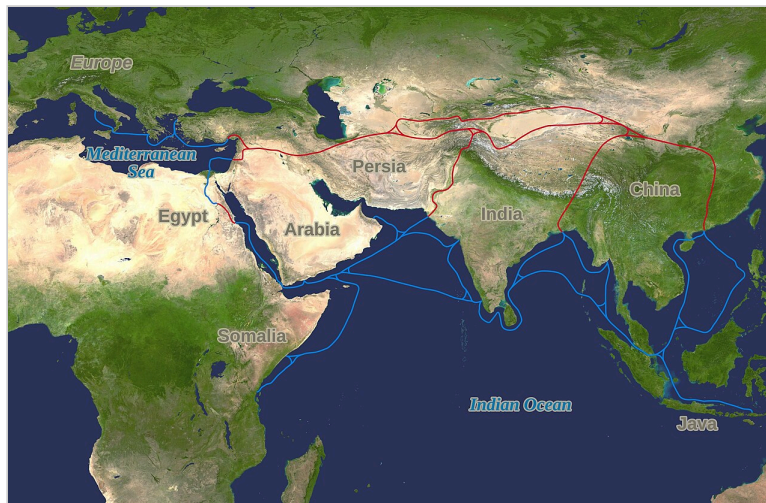
Source A: A 15th-century English manuscript illumination showing peasant agricultural laborers toiling in the fields. The vast majority of Europeans lived in localized poverty, completely oblivious to global trade.

If a traveler from another planet had visited Earth in the year 1450, Western Europe would not have looked like the center of the world. In fact, it would have appeared as an impoverished, cold, and isolated periphery on the outer western edge of Eurasia.

While later generations assumed Europe was always powerful, the mid-15th century reality was stark: England and France were exhausted after the hundred-year conflict of the Hundred Years' War, and populations were still recovering from the devastation of the Black Death. An ordinary European peasant lived in a dark, smokey, single-room hut made of wattle and daub (woven sticks covered in mud) with a thatched roof, sharing the dirt floor with pigs and chickens to stay warm during freezing winters. Their diet was monotonous, consisting almost entirely of 'pottage'—a thick, bland stew of boiled cabbage, peas, and oats.

Ordinary Europeans rarely traveled more than five miles from their birthplace. European kingdoms had few precious minerals, limited manufacturing, and produced almost nothing that merchants in Asia or Africa wished to buy.

Q1. Study Source A. What does this contemporary illumination suggest about the daily reality and living standards of ordinary people in Western Europe around 1450?



The Silk Road trade network: overland caravan routes in red connecting Central Asia to Constantinople, and maritime spice routes in blue. The Ottoman capture of Constantinople cut Europe off from overland transit.

Although ordinary Europeans lived in poverty, wealthy monarchs, nobles, and churchmen were desperate for luxury goods from the East: fine silk and porcelain from China, and exotic spices like pepper, cloves, and cinnamon from India and the Moluccas. For centuries, these goods traveled overland along the ancient **Silk Roads**.

However, directly between Western Europe and Asia stood the rising superpower of the Islamic world: the **Ottoman Empire**. On 29 May 1453, 21-year-old Sultan Mehmed II shattered the ancient stone walls of Constantinople using massive bronze cannons. Mehmed transformed the city into **Istanbul**, the jewel of the Muslim world, and seized control of the ultimate crossroads connecting European trade to the East.

 **Western Europe**
(Desperate for Spices)

BLOCKED BY OTTOMANS ❌

 **The Silk Road**
(Vast Global Wealth)

For European merchants in Venice, Genoa, and London, this was a disaster. The Ottomans slapped heavy taxes on European traders and restricted access to Asian routes. Western Europe was effectively locked out.

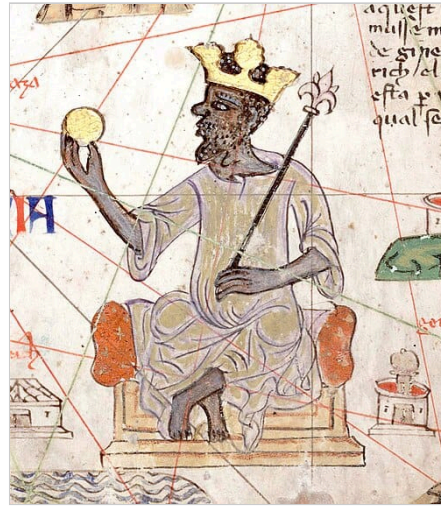
Source B: Eyewitness Diary of Nicolò Barbaro (May 1453)

"On the twenty-ninth of May, 1453, the last day of the siege, our Lord God decided to deliver the city into the hands of the Turks... The blood flowed in the city like rainwater in the gutters after a sudden storm. The corpses were thrown into the sea like melons floating along a canal... The Turks entered with such fury that all Christians who resisted were put to the sword."

— Adapted from the diary of **Nicolò Barbaro**, a Venetian merchant trapped inside Constantinople.

Q2. Study Source B. Why might a Venetian merchant like Nicolò Barbaro have had a biased and particularly panicked view of the Ottoman capture of Constantinople?

Source C



Source C: A detail from the Catalan Atlas (1375) showing Mansa Musa, Emperor of Mali, holding a golden sceptre and a massive gold nugget. European cartographers acknowledged West Africa as the undisputed fountain of global gold.

If Western Europe was an impoverished outpost, where was global wealth and power concentrated in 1450?

1. West Africa: Kingdoms of Gold and Bronze

Sub-Saharan Africa was home to sophisticated, fabulously wealthy civilizations. The **Empire of Mali** sat atop vast gold reserves that supplied the Mediterranean world. Just a century earlier, Mali's emperor, **Mansa Musa**, undertook a pilgrimage to Mecca with dozens of camels bearing pure gold, giving away so much in Cairo that the value of gold plummeted for a decade. Further south in modern Nigeria, the Oba (King) of the **Kingdom of Benin** ruled an immense metropolis protected by thousands of miles of earthwork walls—structures larger than the Great Wall of China. Benin's royal artisans produced world-famous cast-bronze plaques using the intricate lost-wax technique.

2. Ming Dynasty China: The Industrial Giant

At the eastern end of the globe lay **Ming China**, a state of over 100 million people. China was the technological and manufacturing powerhouse of the earth, producing silk, porcelain, and cast iron. Centuries before Europe, China invented gunpowder, paper money, movable-type printing, and the magnetic compass. Between 1405 and 1433, **Admiral Zheng He** commanded seven colossal imperial 'Treasure Fleets'—vessels five times larger than Columbus's *Santa Maria*—patrolling the Indian Ocean and trading as far as East Africa.

Source D



Source D: An authentic 16th-century cast-bronze relief plaque from the royal palace of the Oba of Benin, displaying advanced metallurgical casting and regal court hierarchy.

Q3. Study Sources C and D. How do these two sources challenge traditional Eurocentric assumptions that pre-colonial Africa was 'uncivilized' or poor?

For generations, older school textbooks claimed that European explorers sailed across the oceans after 1492 because Europe was intellectually superior, uniquely adventurous, or destined to 'discover' the world. Modern historians strongly challenge this Eurocentric myth:

Historian Perspective: Professor Peter Frankopan (The Silk Roads, 2015)

"For thousands of years, the pulse of the earth beat not in Europe, but along the Silk Roads... Europe was an outpost, a small region on the edge of the great continent of Eurasia. In 1450, the true wealth, science, and military power of the world lay firmly in the East and in Africa."

The Core Truth: Exploration Out of Desperation

Understanding 1450 fundamentally reframes world history. Western Europe did not launch maritime expeditions because it was wealthy or dominant; **Europe sailed out of sheer economic desperation.** Blockaded by the formidable Ottoman Empire and starving for African gold and Asian spices, Europeans were forced to take desperate risks across uncharted oceans to find a maritime backdoor to the riches of the East.

Q4. Explain TWO reasons why a global traveler in 1450 would have considered Asia and Africa far more powerful and wealthy than Western Europe.

Q5. Explain why Europe was not the centre of global wealth and power in 1450.

L2: How did religious conflict trigger global exploration (1517–1588)?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how the Protestant Reformation shattered European unity after 1517 and turned overseas exploration into an ideological war.
- ☐ Analyze the role of Elizabethan privateers in challenging Catholic Spain's global silver monopoly.
- ☐ Evaluate how the defeat of the Spanish Armada (1588) marked a turning point in Britain's imperial ambitions.

Do Now: Previous Knowledge

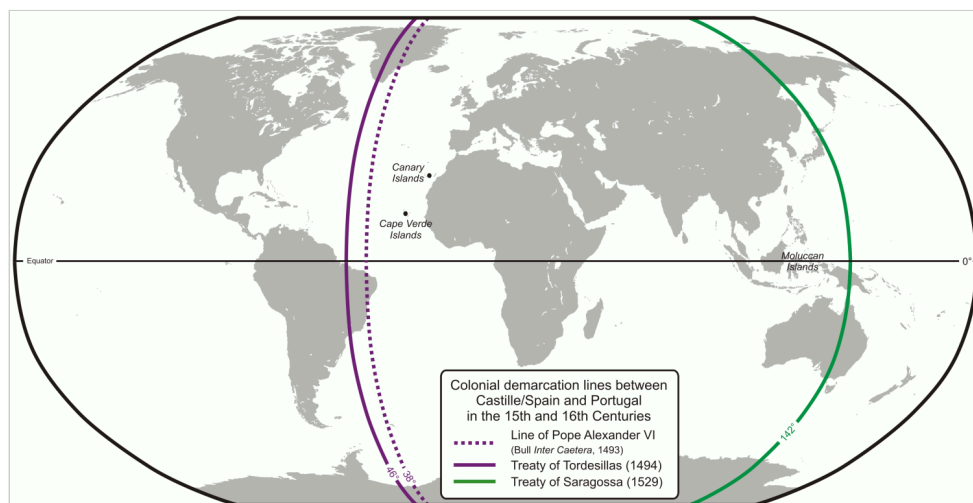
1. What was the overarching name for the ancient trade network connecting Asia to Europe?
2. Which major empire expanded to block overland European trade routes in 1453?
3. What city was captured by Sultan Mehmed II in 1453?
4. What West African kingdom was known for its detailed bronze plaques in the 15th century?
5. Why did the capture of Constantinople force European nations to look for new trade routes?

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: Choose *TWO* terms from the word bank. Write *ONE* grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (*because, although, or consequently*):

Protestant Reformation | Indulgence | Treaty of Tordesillas (1494) | Privateer | Spanish Armada (1588) | Circumnavigation

Teacher Model / Pupil Sentence:



Source A: Map of the Treaty of Tordesillas (1494). Mediated by Pope Alexander VI, this treaty drew a meridian dividing the entire non-European world exclusively between Catholic Spain (west) and Catholic Portugal (east).

To understand why English sailors risked their lives in the uncharted waters of the Atlantic, we have to look back to Germany in 1517. A Catholic monk named **Martin Luther** nailed his **95 Theses** to a church door in Wittenberg, protesting rampant corruption within the Catholic Church—particularly the sale of **indulgences** (certificates sold to forgive sins and shorten time in Purgatory).

Luther's defiance ignited the **Protestant Reformation**, shattering European religious unity and dividing the continent into two mortal enemies:

- **Catholic Powers:** Dominated by the vast Spanish Empire of the Habsburgs and the Papacy in Rome, possessing immense wealth and colossal armies.
- **Protestant Powers:** A collection of northern European territories, Dutch rebels, and eventually England after **King Henry VIII** broke with the Pope in 1534 to establish the Church of England.

This religious fracture immediately spilled into the global oceans. Back in 1494, Pope Alexander VI had brokered the **Treaty of Tordesillas**, drawing an imaginary line down the Atlantic Ocean. The Pope declared that all newly discovered lands to the west belonged exclusively to Catholic Spain, while lands to the east belonged to Catholic Portugal. Catholic Spain claimed a complete, divine monopoly over the wealth of the Americas.

As a Protestant nation, England flatly rejected papal authority. English merchants and captains refused to accept that the Pope had the right to lock them out of the New World. In September 1568, this brewing hostility erupted into bloodshed at the Mexican port of **San Juan de Ulúa**. English captains **Francis Drake** and **John Hawkins** sailed into the port to repair their storm-damaged ships under a signed truce with the Spanish Viceroy. Viewing all Protestant Englishmen in American waters as illegal heretics, the Spanish ambushed the squadron with heavy naval artillery. Drake barely escaped aboard the battered *Judith*, leaving dozens of English sailors to be executed or imprisoned by the Spanish Inquisition. Drake did not view this ambush as a business dispute; he saw it as a holy war. He vowed personal vengeance against King Philip II and the Catholic Church, turning the Atlantic into an ideological battleground.

Q1. Study Source A and read Act 1. Why did the Protestant Reformation and the Pope's division of the world make violent naval conflict between England and Spain inevitable?



Source B: Portrait of Sir Francis Drake (1591) by Marcus Gheeraerts the Younger. Drake rests his hand on a terrestrial globe, wearing the "Drake Jewel" presented to him by Queen Elizabeth I.

When **Queen Elizabeth I** took the English throne, she faced an existential dilemma. England was deeply divided, financially impoverished, and lacked a standing royal navy capable of matching Spain's colossal fleet. Meanwhile, King Philip II of Spain was extracting tons of silver from the mines of Potosí in Bolivia, using this imperial wealth to fund Catholic armies across Europe.

Elizabeth could not afford an open, declared war against Spain. Instead, she waged an asymmetric "cold war" at sea using **privateers**. A privateer was an armed merchant captain granted a royal license—known as a **Letter of Marque**—empowering them to attack, board, and plunder enemy vessels during wartime. To Elizabeth, privateers like Francis Drake, John Hawkins, and Walter Raleigh were cheap, patriotic freedom fighters who filled her empty treasury with captured silver while draining Spain's military budget. To King Philip II and the Spanish, they were ruthless Protestant pirates and heretics led by the terrifying **El Draque** ("The Dragon").

Between 1577 and 1580, Drake pulled off the most daring naval raid in history. Sailing into the Pacific on the *Golden Hind*, where Spanish galleons sailed completely unarmed because they felt totally safe, Drake plundered Spanish ports along Peru and Chile. Off the coast of Ecuador, he captured the Spanish treasure galleon *Nuestra Señora de la Concepción* (nicknamed the *Cacafuego*), seizing 26 tons of silver bullion, 80 pounds of gold, and thirteen chests of royal coins. Drake then completed the second circumnavigation of the globe in human history. When he dropped anchor in Plymouth in 1580, Elizabeth boarded his ship and knighted him on deck—a direct, calculated insult to King Philip II.

Q2. Study Source B and the written evidence. How did the Spanish Catholic perspective of Francis Drake differ from the English Protestant perspective, and what does this reveal about the religious nature of the conflict?



Source C: Contemporary map (1588) by Robert Adams showing the Armada's voyage up the Channel, the scattering off Calais, and the disastrous retreat around the stormy coasts of Scotland and Ireland.

By 1587, King Philip II's patience ran out. Enraged by Drake's relentless piracy, Elizabeth's military support for Dutch Protestant rebels, and the execution of the Catholic **Mary, Queen of Scots** in 1587, Philip decided to conquer England once and for all.

In May 1588, Philip launched the **Spanish Armada** (the *Grande y Felicísima Armada*): 130 massive warships carrying 30,000 soldiers and 2,400 cannons. Philip's master plan was to sail up the English Channel, join forces with the Duke of Parma's veteran Spanish army in the Spanish Netherlands, land in Kent, overthrow Elizabeth, and restore England to Catholicism by force.

The Armada sailed in a formidable, tightly packed **crescent (half-moon) formation** that made boarding actions nearly impossible. However, the English countered with superior naval tactics. Commanded by Lord Howard of Effingham and Sir Francis Drake, English ships were lower, faster "race-built" galleons carrying heavy, long-range naval guns that could reload much faster than Spanish cannons.

The turning point came on the midnight of 7 August 1588 off Calais. The English unleashed eight

fireships—old wooden vessels packed with tar, pitch, and gunpowder set ablaze—and allowed the tide to carry them directly into the crowded Spanish fleet. Terrified Spanish captains cut their heavy anchor cables in panic and scattered into the darkness. The following morning, at the **Battle of Gravelines**, the English battered the disorganised Spanish ships with close-range broadsides.

Defeated and unable to turn back against southwest winds, the surviving Armada fled north around the jagged coasts of Scotland and Ireland. Ferocious Atlantic gales—celebrated by Protestants as the miraculous "**Protestant Wind**"—smashed dozens of Spanish ships against the rocks. Fewer than half of Philip's ships and only 10,000 men ever returned to Spain.

Q3. Explain TWO main reasons why the Spanish Armada failed to invade England in 1588, evaluating whether the defeat was caused primarily by English tactical skill or Spanish misfortune.



Source D: The Armada Portrait of Queen Elizabeth I (c. 1588, attributed to George Gower, Woburn Abbey version). Packed with imperial symbolism, it depicts Elizabeth claiming global mastery following the defeat of Spain.

The defeat of the Spanish Armada was a profound psychological and geopolitical watershed. While the Anglo-Spanish war dragged on until 1604, the victory of 1588 shattered the myth of Spanish naval invincibility and unleashed an explosion of English national pride and imperial ambition.

No historical artifact captures this moment better than **The Armada Portrait of Queen Elizabeth I** (c. 1588, attributed to George Gower). Commissioned to celebrate the victory, the painting is packed with sophisticated political and religious iconography:

- **The Globe and North America:** Elizabeth's right hand rests purposefully on the globe, with her fingers spread directly over North America. The message was unmistakable: England was no longer content to stay on its island; it was claiming the right to colonize the Americas and challenge Spain for global dominion.
- **The Contrasting Windows:** The window behind her right shoulder shows the English fleet sailing in calm, golden sunlight, while the window behind her left shoulder shows the Spanish Armada being battered and wrecked against stormy rocks by God's "Protestant Wind".
- **The Crown and the Mermaid:** An imperial closed crown sits beside her, asserting that England was an empire answerable to no foreign Pope or Emperor, while a carved mermaid on her throne symbolizes mastery over the wild oceans.
- **The Pearls:** Elizabeth's dress is encrusted with over 800 pearls, symbolizing virginity, purity, and the precious oceanic wealth brought back by global privateers.

For centuries, British historians celebrated 1588 as a divine miracle that founded the British Empire. Modern historians, however, emphasize that the Armada did not instantly create an empire—England still had no permanent American colonies. Instead, 1588 gave the English the *confidence* and the *ideological justification* to build one. As writer Richard Hakluyt argued, colonisation was now England's sacred duty: to spread Protestantism, liberate Indigenous peoples from Spanish brutality, and bring glory to the realm.

Q4. Study Source D (The Armada Portrait). How does the artist use specific visual symbols in this painting to project Elizabeth's royal authority and announce England's arrival as a global maritime empire?

✂ SIDE QUEST: THE HORRORS OF SCURVY



Source E: Historical medical documentation illustrating the horrifying effects of scurvy on a sailor's gums and teeth.

The "Golden Age of Exploration" is often painted as a heroic era of brave captains claiming glory. But for the ordinary sailors on ships like Francis Drake's *Golden Hind*, life was a living nightmare of disease and malnutrition. The greatest enemy was not the Spanish navy, but **scurvy**—a terrifying disease caused by a severe lack of Vitamin C on voyages lasting months without fresh fruit or vegetables. Because fresh supplies spoiled quickly, sailors survived on rock-hard, weevil-infested "hard tack" biscuits and salted beef that had often turned green. Without Vitamin C, the human body cannot produce collagen: a sailor's gums would swell, turn purple, and rot; their teeth would fall out; old healed scars would miraculously rip open again; and they would slowly bleed to death internally. On many Elizabethan expeditions, over half the crew died of scurvy before ever engaging the enemy in combat.

Think-Pair-Share: Q5 Why did Elizabethan propaganda and later history textbooks emphasize the 'patriotic glory' of captains like Francis Drake, while ignoring the grim reality that over half of ordinary sailors died from scurvy and malnutrition?

1. My Thoughts (Think)	2. Partner's Thoughts (Pair)

Q6. Explain how religious conflict between Catholics and Protestants pushed England into global exploration and naval rivalry with Spain between 1517 and 1588.

L3: Trade or takeover: How did early encounters turn into empire?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how joint-stock corporations (like the East India Company and Virginia Company) funded early English expansion.
- ☐ Compare the early English colonial encounters in North America (Jamestown) with mercantile trade in Mughal India.
- ☐ Evaluate the turning point where peaceful commercial trade shifted into territorial takeover and empire.

Do Now: Previous Knowledge

1. In what year did Martin Luther post his 95 Theses?
2. What name was given to English sailors, like Francis Drake, who were given legal permission to attack Spanish ships?
3. What was the name of the Spanish King who launched the Armada against England in 1588?
4. What weather event destroyed much of the fleeing Spanish Armada off the coast of Scotland?
5. Why did Queen Elizabeth I use privateers instead of the Royal Navy to challenge Spain in the Americas?

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:

Joint-Stock Company | East India Company (EIC) | Royal Charter | Factory (Trading Post) | Mughal Empire | Jamestown (1607)

Power, Governance & Warfare

Economy, Trade & Society



Source A: Engraving of Matoaka (Pocahontas) in London (1616) by Simon van de Passe. Commissioned by the Virginia Company, this portrait was designed as corporate propaganda to persuade English investors that the colony was civilized and profitable.

Unlike the Spanish Empire, where the King directly financed conquistadors and royal invasion fleets, early English global expansion was fundamentally commercial and corporate. In the early seventeenth century, the English Crown was cash-strapped and deeply in debt. English monarchs could not afford to finance expensive transatlantic voyages or overseas armies from the royal treasury.

To solve this problem, wealthy English merchants developed a revolutionary financial invention: the **Joint-Stock Company**. Instead of one wealthy merchant risking total ruin if a ship sank, hundreds of private investors pooled their capital to buy shares in a corporate venture. If a voyage succeeded, profits were divided among shareholders; if a ship sank, each investor lost only their initial investment. This dramatically spread financial risk and mobilized unprecedented private capital.

To protect these investments, the Crown issued formal legal decrees known as **Royal Charters**. A Royal Charter granted a company a strict legal monopoly over trade in a specific part of the world, along with extraordinary semi-governmental powers: the right to establish colonies, mint private currency, build armed fortresses, and raise private security forces. On 31 December 1600, Queen Elizabeth I chartered the **East India Company (EIC)**, granting a 15-year monopoly on all English trade in Asia. Six years later, in 1606, King James I chartered the **Virginia Company of London** to establish settlements in North America.

To convince cautious London aristocrats to invest in these ventures, chartered companies launched aggressive marketing campaigns. In 1616, the Virginia Company brought **Matoaka** (known to the English as Pocahontas), daughter of the paramount chief of the Powhatan Confederacy, to London. Dressed in high-status Jacobean silk and an aristocratic lace ruff, she was presented to King James I and depicted in engravings as a living advertisement, demonstrating to wealthy investors that Virginia was a "civilized", peaceful, and commercially viable land worthy of their gold.

Q1. Study Source A and read Act 1. Why did the English Crown rely on private joint-stock companies (like the Virginia Company and East India Company) to explore the world, and how did these companies market their ventures to investors?



Source B: Architectural plan of James Fort (1608), sketched by Spanish spy Pedro de Zúñiga. The triangular wooden palisade featured raised corner bastions with artillery, showing that settlers prioritized defense and military fortification.

In May 1607, three Virginia Company ships carrying 104 men and boys sailed up the James River in Chesapeake Bay and established **Jamestown**—England's first permanent settlement in North America. The early years of the colony were a catastrophic struggle for survival. Chosen for its defensibility against Spanish naval raids, the site was a swampy peninsula plagued by mosquitoes, malaria, and brackish, undrinkable water. Most of the original settlers were "gentlemen" who refused to perform manual labour or farm, expecting to find gold just as the Spanish had in Peru.

During the horrific winter of 1609–1610—known as the "**Starving Time**"—relations with the indigenous Powhatan Confederacy collapsed. The Powhatan cut off food trade and besieged the settlement. Trapped inside their wooden fort, settlers starved: only 60 of the 500 colonists survived the winter, surviving on horses, dogs, rats, snakes, shoe leather, and, in documented cases, cannibalism.

The colony was ultimately rescued by two developments. First, in 1612, settler John Rolfe introduced sweet Spanish tobacco seeds, discovering that Virginia's soil was ideally suited for tobacco cultivation. Tobacco became a lucrative cash-crop that flooded European markets with addictive "brown gold", ensuring the Virginia Company's financial survival. Second, to defend their valuable crop and protect against Powhatan archers, the settlers constructed **James Fort**: a heavy, triangular wooden palisade with circular corner bastions mounting heavy cannons.

However, tobacco cultivation required vast amounts of fertile land and quickly exhausted the soil. As tobacco profits soared, settlers cleared forests, invaded native hunting grounds, and seized agricultural land. Despite the brief peace that followed the marriage of John Rolfe and Matoaka in 1614, English land hunger made peace impossible. In North America, English expansion became an aggressive **territorial takeover**: building defensive forts, clearing forests, and violently displacing Indigenous populations to secure land.

Q2. Study Source B (Plan of James Fort) and read Act 2. What does the triangular, heavily armed design of James Fort reveal about why early English encounters in North America rapidly shifted from trade into territorial takeover?



Source C: Mughal miniature portrait of Emperor Jahangir (c. 1615–1620). Depicted with an imperial golden halo and opulent pearl necklaces, this image reflects the immense wealth and authority of the Mughal Empire when Sir Thomas Roe arrived as an ambassador.

While English settlers in Virginia were aggressively seizing land and building wooden fortresses, the East India Company was experiencing a completely different reality on the other side of the globe. In 1600, India was ruled by the colossal **Mughal Empire**—one of the wealthiest and most sophisticated superpowers in world history. The Mughal Empire ruled over 100 million subjects, commanded armies with thousands of war elephants and cannons, and produced a staggering 25% of the entire world's manufactured output, particularly luxury calico cottons, fine silks, and spices.

By comparison, Stuart England was a minor, peripheral island with a population of just 4 million and an economy contributing less than 2% of world GDP. English mariners who sailed into the Indian Ocean had zero military advantage. They could not threaten, conquer, or seize territory from the mighty Mughal emperors.

In 1615, King James I dispatched diplomat **Sir Thomas Roe** as England's first official ambassador to the court of Mughal Emperor **Jahangir** at Ajmer. When Roe arrived, he was overwhelmed by the breathtaking magnificence of the Mughal court. Jahangir sat on imperial thrones draped in emeralds, rubies, and pearls, wearing cloth-of-gold robes that made English courtiers look impoverished.

Recognizing England's total military and economic inferiority, Sir Thomas Roe understood that conquest was impossible. Instead, Roe had to adopt a strategy of humble, polite subservience. For four years, Roe prostrated himself before Jahangir, presented European gifts (clocks, fine English mastiff hunting dogs, and world maps), and flattered the Emperor. In 1619, Jahangir finally granted Roe a *firman* (royal decree) permitting English merchants to establish a small, rented coastal warehouse—known as a **factory (trading post)**—at the port of Surat. In India, the English could not act as conquerors; they were humble merchants begging for permission to trade.

Q3. Compare Source B (James Fort in Virginia) and Source C (Emperor Jahangir). Why did early English encounters in North America result in immediate fortified takeover, whereas in Mughal India the English were forced to remain humble, polite traders?



Source D: View of the Thirteen Factories in Canton, China (c. 1800). For centuries, European merchants were strictly confined to narrow coastal warehouses ("factories") outside Chinese city walls, showing that early global trade was negotiated on Asian terms.

For over a century, the East India Company adhered strictly to Sir Thomas Roe's advice: *"A war and traffic [trade] are incompatible... Let this be received as a rule, that if you will profit, seek it at sea, and in quiet trade."* Throughout the seventeenth century, English merchants remained confined to fortified coastal warehouses—such as Bombay, Madras, and Calcutta in India, and the famous **Thirteen Factories** in Canton, China, where European merchants were strictly locked outside the city walls by Qing imperial authorities.

However, in the mid-eighteenth century, the geopolitical landscape changed radically. Following the death of Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb in 1707, the central authority of the Mughal Empire fractured into dozens of rival, warring regional kingdoms. Sensing an opportunity to eliminate their French commercial rivals and secure tax revenues, the East India Company began militarizing its trading posts. The EIC recruited and trained thousands of Indian soldiers—known as **sepoys**—equipping them with modern European flintlock muskets and field artillery.

The decisive turning point occurred in 1757 at the **Battle of Plassey**. Commanded by Robert Clive, a small army of 3,000 British troops and sepoy defeated the 50,000-strong army of Siraj ud-Daulah, the Nawab of Bengal, after bribing the Nawab's chief commander, Mir Jafar. In 1765, the shattered Mughal Emperor

was forced to sign the Treaty of Allahabad, granting the private East India Company the **Diwani**: the legal right to collect all agricultural taxes from 20 million people in Bengal.

Historians fiercely debate the nature of this transition. In 1883, imperial historian Sir John Robert Seeley famously claimed that the British Empire was acquired "*in a fit of absence of mind*"—arguing that peaceful merchants were accidentally dragged into Indian politics to protect trade. Modern historians, such as Shashi Tharoor (*Inglorious Empire*, 2017), strongly reject this, arguing that the East India Company was always an aggressive, profit-driven capitalist machine that used bribery, military violence, and economic exploitation to ruthlessly conquer India for corporate gain.

Q4. Study Source D and read Act 4. How do historians disagree over whether the British Empire developed "accidentally" through peaceful trade, or as an "inevitable takeover" driven by corporate greed and military force?

SIDE QUEST: THE INVASION OF THE PIGS



Source E: John White's authentic 1585 watercolor painting of the Algonquian village of Secotan, showing their carefully managed, unfenced corn fields.

When history textbooks discuss the English colonization of North America, they focus almost entirely on muskets, land treaties, and tobacco. But one of the most destructive biological weapons the English brought to Virginia was the domesticated pig. The Algonquian Powhatan people did not build fences; they carefully managed open forest lands and planted unfenced polyculture fields of maize, beans, and squash. The English settlers, however, allowed their livestock to roam freely in the woods. Hundreds of feral pigs multiplied rapidly, invading native villages, rooting up delicate native edible plants, devouring winter seed stores, and trampling coastal clam beds that Native Americans depended on for winter protein. For the Indigenous peoples, English colonization was not merely a political or military invasion; it was an ecological catastrophe that literally consumed their food supply from the ground up.

Think-Pair-Share: Q5 How does this ecological detail ("The Invasion of the Pigs") change our historical understanding of why Native Americans became hostile toward the Jamestown settlers?

1. My Thoughts (Think)	2. Partner's Thoughts (Pair)

Q6. Explain why early English global encounters between 1600 and 1750 shifted from peaceful mercantile trade into armed takeover and empire.

L4: James I and the Gunpowder Plot: Why was religious division so volatile?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how the Elizabethan legacy and King James I's broken promises heightened Catholic desperation by 1604.
- ☐ Analyse the conspiracy hatched by Robert Catesby and Guy Fawkes beneath Parliament and evaluate the discovery through the Monteagle Letter.
- ☐ Evaluate competing historical interpretations regarding whether Robert Cecil discovered or manufactured the conspiracy.

Vocabulary Check

Spot the Deliberate Error: Read the statement below. One historical fact or vocabulary concept has been deliberately falsified. Underline the error and explain the accurate historical reality below:

Recusant | Divine Right of Kings | Undercroft | The Rack | Penal Laws | State Entrapment

"In 1605, King James I abandoned the Divine Right of Kings and rewarded every Catholic Recusant with seats in Parliament, completely eliminating the need for Penal Laws."

Teacher Model / Historical Correction:



Source A: Portrait of King James I (c. 1606) by John de Critz. James believed passionately in the Divine Right of Kings, yet his decision in 1604 to expel Catholic priests and collect crushing recusancy fines triggered radical unrest.

[1.1] In seventeenth-century England, religion was not a private matter of personal conscience; it was the foundation of national security, monarchical authority, and daily survival.

[1.2] Decades of religious upheaval following the Protestant Reformation and the 1588 Spanish Armada had created an atmosphere of deep paranoia between Protestants and Catholics.

[1.3] English Catholics who refused to attend compulsory Church of England Sunday services were branded as **recusants**.

[1.4] Under Queen Elizabeth I, the Crown imposed staggering recusancy fines of £20 a month—an astronomical sum designed to financially cripple Catholic landowners and force them into submission.

[1.5] Harboring an ordained Catholic priest was legally classified as high treason, punishable by the agonizing public death of hanging, drawing, and quartering.

[1.6] Priests lived in perpetual terror, celebrating secret Latin masses at dawn and hiding in cramped secret compartments known as **priest holes**, ingeniously built into manor walls by master carpenter Nicholas Owen.

[1.7] When the childless Queen Elizabeth I died in March 1603, English Catholics felt a surge of desperate optimism.

[1.8] The throne passed to King James VI of Scotland (now **King James I** of England), the son of the executed Catholic martyr Mary, Queen of Scots.

[1.9] James had secretly written to Catholic peers before his accession, promising that he would not "persecute any that will be quiet and give an outward obedience to the law."

[1.10] However, once crowned in London, James was politically trapped: fiercely believing in the **Divine Right of Kings** and anxious to prove his Protestant orthodoxy to a suspicious Parliament, James abruptly reversed course.

[1.11] In February 1604, James issued a royal proclamation expelling all Catholic priests from England and ruthlessly collected back-taxes on unpaid recusancy fines.

[1.12] For a zealous minority of young Catholic gentlemen, this betrayal proved that peaceful reform was impossible and that God commanded armed action.

Q1. Study Source A and read Act 1. Using sentences [1.3], [1.4], [1.9], and [1.11], explain why English Catholics felt deeply betrayed by King James I, and how this deepened religious volatility in Jacobean England.



Source B: Contemporary Dutch print (1605) by Crispijn van de Passe the Elder, showing Robert Catesby, Guy Fawkes, Thomas Percy, and fellow plotters conspiring in broad-brimmed hats and dark cloaks.

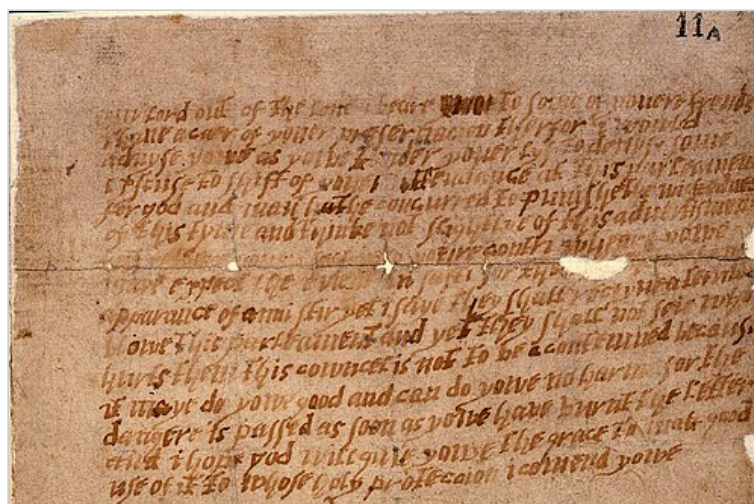
[2.1] In May 1604, five militant Catholic gentlemen met secretly at the Duck and Drake inn near the Strand in London. Their charismatic leader was **Robert Catesby**, a tall, persuasive Northamptonshire gentleman whose father had been imprisoned by Elizabeth and whose family estate had been bled dry by recusancy

finer. Catesby argued that petty rebellions and local uprisings were useless; only a catastrophic blow at the heart of government could overthrow the Protestant regime. His audacious scheme was to blow up the House of Lords during the State Opening of Parliament, wiping out King James I, his eldest sons Prince Henry and Prince Charles, the bishops, and the entire ruling Protestant aristocracy in a single second.

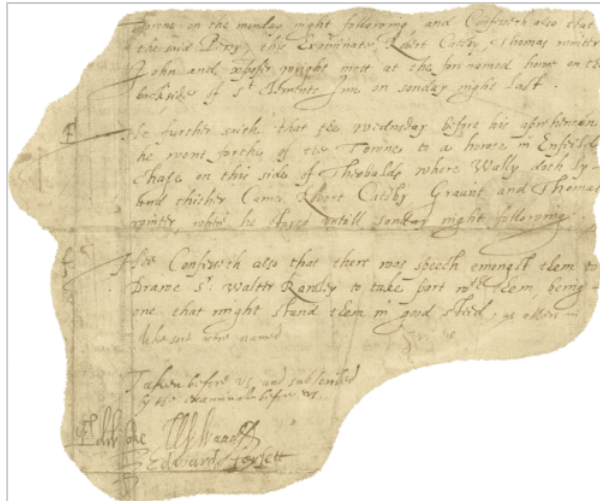
[2.2] To execute this mass demolition, Catesby enlisted an experienced mercenary: **Guido (Guy) Fawkes**. Born into a prominent Protestant family in York, Fawkes had converted to Catholicism in his youth and spent ten brutal years fighting for the Spanish Army of Flanders. He was a seasoned military engineer with expert knowledge of mining, sapping, and gunpowder. Using the alias **John Johnson**, Fawkes posed as the humble servant of co-conspirator Thomas Percy. In March 1605, Percy used his royal connections to lease a ground-floor **undercroft** (cellar) situated directly beneath the House of Lords chamber, where peers and the King would assemble.

[2.3] Under cover of darkness, the plotters ferried **36 barrels of gunpowder**—roughly 2.5 tonnes of high explosive—across the River Thames from Lambeth, concealing them beneath massive piles of firewood, coal, and iron bars designed to act as shrapnel. The conspirators planned a synchronized nationwide coup: while Fawkes ignited a slow-burning match in London and escaped to Flanders by ship, conspirators led by Sir Everard Digby would launch an armed Catholic rebellion in the Midlands. They intended to storm Coombe Abbey, kidnap King James's nine-year-old daughter **Princess Elizabeth**, proclaim her Catholic Queen, and marry her to a Catholic nobleman. However, because Parliament was repeatedly postponed due to plague outbreaks, the plot dragged on for eighteen months, forcing Catesby to recruit more wealthy backers and dangerously widening the circle of secrets.

Q2. Study Source B and read Act 2. Using paragraphs [2.1] and [2.2], explain Robert Catesby's operational plan, and analyse how the visual representation in Source B shaped public perceptions of Catholic conspirators.



Source C: The Monteagle Letter (October 1605), National Archives SP 14/19/1. Written in disguised handwriting, this unsigned letter warned Monteagle to avoid Parliament's opening.



Source D: Confession document (November 1605) showing Guido Fawkes's firm initial signature compared with his faint, trembling signature executed after severe stretching on the rack.

The Anonymous Warning Letter to Lord Monteagle (26 October 1605)

1 my lord out of the love i beare to some of youere frends i have a caer of youre preservacion
 5 therfor i would advyse yowe as yowe tender youre lyf to devyse some excuse to shift of
 10 youre attendance at this parleament for god and man hathe concurred to punishe the wickednes
 15 of this tyme and thinke not slightlye of this advertisment but retyere youre self into youre
 20 contri wheare yowe maye expect the event in safti for thowghe theare be no apparence of anni
 25 stir yet i saye they shall receyve a terrible blowe this parleament and yet they shall not seie who hurts them
 30 this councel is not to be contemned because it maye do yowe goode and can do yowe no harme for the dangere is passed as soon as yowe have burnt the letter...

On the evening of 26 October 1605, the conspiracy began to unravel. Catholic peer **Lord Monteagle** was dining at his home in Hoxton when a servant handed him an anonymous letter delivered by a cloaked stranger in the street.

The unsigned letter contained a chilling warning: Monteagle immediately rode to Whitehall Palace and handed the letter to **Robert Cecil, Earl of Salisbury**, King James's brilliant Chief Minister and Spymaster. Rather than rushing to search Parliament immediately, Cecil waited deliberately for ten days until King James returned from a hunting trip in Royston, allowing the King to "miraculously divine" the explosive meaning of a "blow".

Just after midnight on the morning of **5 November 1605**, Sir Thomas Knyvett led an armed search of the undercroft beneath the House of Lords. There, standing beside 36 barrels of gunpowder hidden under firewood, they arrested Guy Fawkes, dressed in boots and spurs and carrying a pocket watch, touchwood, and slow matches.

Fawkes was dragged before King James in his bedchamber, remaining defiantly unrepentant. When asked by a Scottish nobleman what he intended to do with so much gunpowder, Fawkes coldly replied: "To blow you Scotch beggars back into your native mountains!"

Fawkes was imprisoned in the Tower of London. On 6 November, King James signed a royal warrant authorizing the use of torture: *"The gentler tortours are to be first used unto him, and so by degrees proceeding to the worst."* Fawkes was subjected to **the rack** for several agonizing days. His physical destruction is graphically preserved in official court papers: his initial bold signature ("Guido Fawkes") deteriorated into a faint, broken scrawl ("Guido"), after which his hand gave out completely. Breaking under torture, Fawkes revealed the names of his co-conspirators.

The remaining plotters fled in panic to the Midlands, making a desperate last stand on 8 November at **Holbeche House** in Staffordshire. Surrounded by the Sheriff of Worcester's armed posse, Robert Catesby and Thomas Percy were shot dead with a single musket ball while standing back-to-back. The surviving conspirators were brought to London, tried for high treason in Westminster Hall, and publicly hanged, drawn, and quartered in Old Palace Yard in January 1606.

Q3. Study Sources C and D alongside Act 3. Analyse how the textual evidence of the Monteagle Letter (lines 10–25) and the forensic evidence of Fawkes's signatures (Source D) illuminate the methods used by the Jacobean state to investigate and punish high treason.



Source E: Contemporary print showing the gruesome public execution of the surviving Gunpowder Plotters in Old Palace Yard, Westminster (January 1606).

In the centuries since 1605, the Gunpowder Plot has stood as one of the most contentious episodes in British history. While Jacobean government propaganda presented the discovery as a miraculous act of God saving Protestant England, modern historians remain divided over the true role played by King James's Chief Minister, Robert Cecil.

Was the plot an authentic Catholic conspiracy that nearly destroyed the English state, or was it an elaborate sting operation manipulated by the Jacobean secret service?

Read the two competing historical interpretations below:

Interpretation 1: The Genuine Terror Plot

"The Gunpowder Plot was a genuine, desperate terror conspiracy conceived and organised entirely by Robert Catesby and his

Interpretation 2: The State Entrapment Thesis

inner circle of disaffected Catholic gentlemen. The plotters procured their own gunpowder, leased the undercroft through Thomas Percy's royal connections, and came within hours of catastrophic success. While Robert Cecil exploited the plot masterfully after receiving the Monteagle letter to destroy the Catholic missionary network, there is no credible evidence that he invented the conspiracy or orchestrated it from the start. The conspirators died fighting at Holbeche House precisely because their violent mission was entirely real."

— Historian Antonia Fraser, *Faith and Treason: The Story of the Gunpowder Plot* (1996)

"The Gunpowder Plot was an elaborate sting operation manipulated, if not actively facilitated, by Robert Cecil, Earl of Salisbury. As head of the Jacobean secret service, Cecil controlled the government gunpowder monopoly and had spies trailing Catesby's circle for months. By allowing 36 barrels into Parliament's undercroft and choreographing the 'miraculous discovery' through the convenient Monteagle letter, Cecil manufactured a national panic that permanently blackened English Catholicism, secured massive parliamentary taxes, and cemented his personal supremacy over King James."

— Historian Francis Edwards, *The Gunpowder Plot: The Narrative of 1605* (1969)

The consequences of the plot were immense. Parliament passed the **Observance of 5th November Act 1605** (making annual bonfire celebrations compulsory by law) and enacted the **Popish Recusants Act 1606**, requiring Catholics to swear a humiliating Oath of Allegiance and barring them from practicing law, medicine, or voting. Religious volatility had hardened into permanent institutional discrimination.

Q4. Study Act 4 and compare Interpretation 1 and Interpretation 2. Which historian's argument provides a more convincing explanation of Robert Cecil's role in the Gunpowder Plot?

Q5. How far do you agree with Interpretation 1 that the Gunpowder Plot was a genuine, independently hatched Catholic conspiracy, rather than an entrapment scheme orchestrated or manipulated by Robert Cecil?

L5: Who controlled Britain? The Ideological Battle

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Analyze why King Charles I and Parliament fought the English Civil War (1642–1651).
- ☐ Evaluate how colonial wealth from sugar and tobacco reshaped British politics during the Commonwealth.
- ☐ Debate who held true power in Britain by 1660: the Monarchy, Parliament, or Atlantic Capitalists.

Do Now: Previous Knowledge

1. What was the name of the first permanent English settlement in North America (1607)?
2. Which cash crop saved the Jamestown colony from economic ruin?
3. What type of business model was the East India Company (EIC), where multiple investors pooled money?
4. Which powerful Asian empire did Sir Thomas Roe visit in 1615?
5. Why were the English submissive traders in India, but aggressive conquerors in North America?

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Select *THREE* terms that share a close historical connection. Identify which *ONE* remaining term is the 'Odd One Out' in this lesson, and explain your historical reasoning:

English Civil War (1642–1651) | New Model Army | Regicide | The Commonwealth | Puritanism | Levellers

Teacher Model / Pupil Reasoning:

The East Offering its Riches to Britannia (1778)



Notice how Britannia sits elevated, while figures representing Asia, Africa, and India offer her their goods. This painting was placed on the ceiling of the East India Company's headquarters, literally looking down on the directors as they made decisions about global trade.

A ceiling painting by Spiridione Roma (1778), originally commissioned for the Revenue Committee Room at East India House. It is an allegorical painting showing Britannia's wealth, receiving jewels, spices, and silk from Asia, Africa, and India. It highlights the ideology and wealth of Britain's empire.

Q1 How useful is this painting as evidence of Britain's global power and ideology in 1778?

Q2 Study Source A. Why did the monarch combine the English and Scottish symbols into a single Coat of Arms?

Source A



The Coat of Arms of Great Britain following the Hanoverian succession in 1714. This era saw the stabilization of a constitutional monarchy where Parliament, rather than the King, held ultimate financial and political authority.

Source B



A contemporary engraving by John Weesop depicting the execution of King Charles I outside the Banqueting House in Whitehall, 1649. His trial and execution for high treason marked a radical shift in power, proving that an English monarch could be held legally accountable by his own subjects.

At 2:00 PM on Tuesday, 30 January 1649, a man in a black velvet coat stepped out of a window of the Banqueting House in Whitehall, London, onto a wooden scaffold draped in black cloth.

The man was **King Charles I**. Below him stood thousands of silent onlookers, surrounded by ranks of iron-armored cavalry. For seven years, England had been ripped apart by a bloody Civil War that cost the lives of nearly 200,000 people—a higher proportion of the population than died in the First World War.

Charles put his head on the wooden block. He stretched out his hands—the prearranged signal—and the

masked executioner's axe severed his head with a single blow. The executioner held the dripping head aloft and shouted: *"Behold the head of a traitor!"*

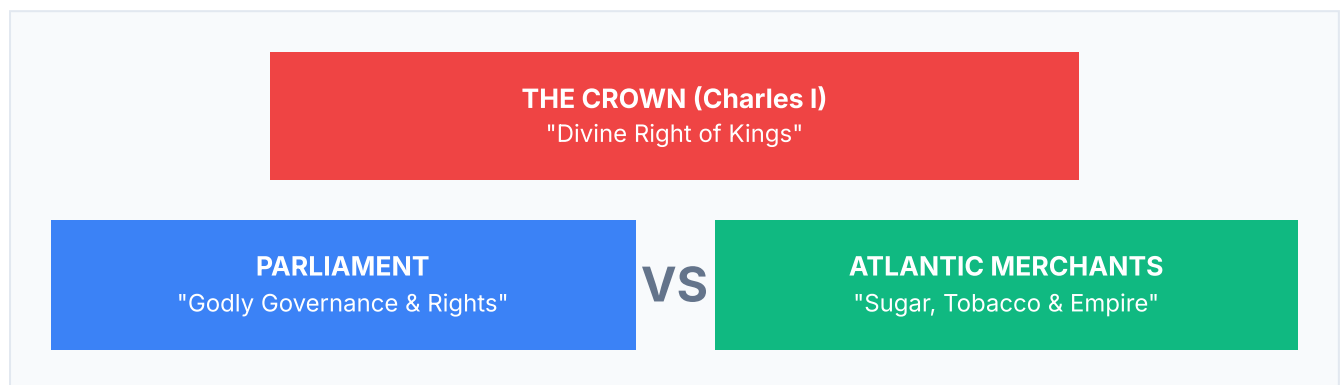
A collective groan echoed through the crowd. Never before in European history had a monarch been put on trial, condemned, and executed by his own Parliament.

But who was really pulling the strings? Was this victory brought about by high-minded Parliamentary ideals of liberty? Or was it secretly fueled by a new class of ultra-rich Atlantic merchants whose sugar and tobacco profits were reshaping the British state?

Q3. Why was the execution of King Charles I such a shocking event in European history?

Q4. Study Source A. Why did the monarch combine the English and Scottish symbols into a single Coat of Arms?

To understand this chaotic era, we must investigate three competing forces battling for the soul—and wealth—of Britain.



Contender 1: The King & "Divine Right" (Charles I)

Charles I believed in the **Divine Right of Kings**—the conviction that God alone chose monarchs to rule, making royal authority absolute.

- **The Spark:** Between 1629 and 1640, Charles ruled without calling Parliament at all (**The Eleven Years' Tyranny**). To raise money without Parliament's consent, he forced illegal taxes on the nation, such as **Ship Money**.
- **The Explosion:** When Charles marched into the House of Commons with 400 armed soldiers in 1642 to arrest five MP leaders, Parliament revolted. War broke out: **Royalists (Cavaliers)** supporting the King vs. **Parliamentarians (Roundheads)** fighting for parliamentary consent.

Contender 2: Parliament & Cromwell's New Model Army

Parliament won the Civil War not because of noble speeches, but because of a revolutionary military machine: **The New Model Army**.

Led by a strict Puritan country gentleman named **Oliver Cromwell**, this army was built on merit rather than noble birth. Soldiers sang religious psalms as they charged into battle at Naseby (1645) and Preston (1648).

When Charles I was executed in 1649, monarchy was abolished. Britain was declared a republic: **The Commonwealth of England**. By 1653, Cromwell dismissed Parliament at swordpoint, taking total power as **Lord Protector**—a military dictator who banned Christmas, theater, and sports.

Contender 3: The Atlantic Merchant Elite

While Royalists and Roundheads were hacking each other to pieces on English battlefields, a silent economic revolution was happening in the Caribbean and North America.

In the 1640s, English planters in **Barbados** transformed the island from tobacco farming to mass **sugar plantation production** powered by enslaved African labor. Sugar was nicknamed "white gold."

- A single acre of Barbados sugar produced **ten times more profit** than an acre of English wheat.
- By 1650, Barbados generated more export wealth than all the North American colonies combined.

The Hidden Link: The merchants who grew rich off Caribbean sugar and Virginian tobacco were almost all ardent supporters of Parliament. They hated Charles I because his royal monopolies interfered with their free trade. They poured millions into funding Cromwell's New Model Army.

When Cromwell took power, he used their money to build the **Commonwealth Navy** and passed the **Navigation Acts (1651)**—laws stating that all colonial goods had to be carried on English ships, effectively seizing global trade from the Dutch!

Q5. How did the Atlantic Merchants use their wealth to influence the outcome of the English Civil War?

Work like a professional historian. Examine these three rare primary sources from the 1640s and 1650s to identify where the true power lay.

Source B: The Charge Against King Charles I (Read at his Trial, January 1649)

"That the said Charles Stuart, being admitted King of England, and therein trusted with a limited power to govern by and according to the laws of the land... hath traitorously and maliciously levied war against the present Parliament and the people therein represented... for the erecting and upholding to himself of an unlimited and tyrannical power."

— **John Bradshaw**, President of the High Court of Justice.

Source C: A London Merchant's Pamphlet on Sugar Profits (1654)

"This small island of Barbados doth yield more wealth to the Commonwealth than any kingdom in Europe... Our ships return laden with sweetness, paying thousands in customs to

the state, and maintaining hundreds of brave sailors. Without the trade of the West Indies, the New Model Army would starve for want of pay."

— **Adapted from a pamphlet by Maurice Thompson**, London merchant and slave trader.

Source D: Oliver Cromwell's Speech Dismissing the Rump Parliament (1653)

"It is high time for me to put an end to your sitting in this place, which you have dishonoured by your contempt of all virtue... You are an factious crew! Ye are noblemen for gold; ye are lovers of money, not justice! In the name of God, go!"

— **Oliver Cromwell**, speaking to MPs on 20 April 1653 before locking the doors of Parliament.

Think-Pair-Share: Q6 How does Source C reveal a completely different reason for Parliament's victory over the King compared to the official reason given in Source B?

1. My Thoughts (Think)	2. Partner's Thoughts (Pair)

Q7. Look at Source D. What does Cromwell accuse MPs of becoming? Why is this ironic given that merchant wealth helped bring Cromwell to power?

Source F:

Interpretation A: Professor Christopher Hill (The Political View)

"The English Civil War was a revolutionary class struggle. It permanently smashed the absolute monarchy and the old feudal order, transferring political power to Parliament and the middling sorts."

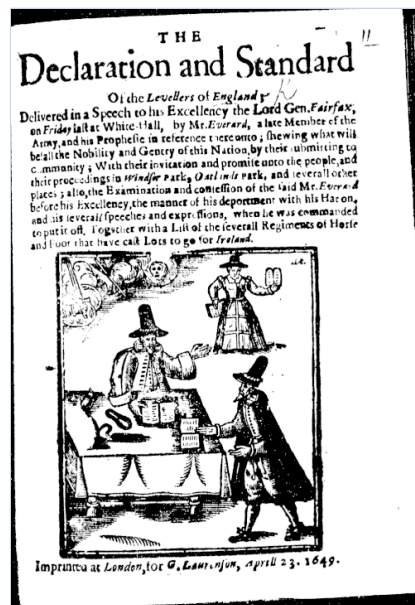
Interpretation B: Professor Eric Williams (The Imperial/Economic View)

"The true victors of the 17th century were the imperial merchant classes. By restricting the monarchy, Parliament secured the political stability needed to build the massive joint-stock companies (like the East India Company and the Royal African Company) which extracted vast wealth through colonization and slavery."

Q8. Which historian argues that the conflict was primarily about political and class rights, and which argues it was about establishing the conditions for global capitalism and empire?



SIDE QUEST: THE DIGGERS AND THE DREAM OF EQUALITY



Source G: The authentic title page of the radical 1649 pamphlet 'The True Levellers Standard Advanced' by Gerrard Winstanley.

History usually remembers the English Civil War as a battle between King Charles I and Oliver Cromwell. But among the ordinary foot soldiers of the New Model Army and the desperate, starving peasants, radical new ideas were brewing. A group known as the Diggers (or True Levellers) believed that the war shouldn't just replace a King with a Parliament; it should wipe out poverty entirely. Led by Gerrard Winstanley in 1649, the Diggers marched onto privately owned land at St George's Hill in Surrey and simply started planting vegetables, declaring that the earth was a 'common treasury for all' and that private property should be abolished. They envisioned a radically modern, equal, bottom-up democracy. Tragically, this was too extreme for Cromwell and the wealthy landowners, who quickly used the army to violently crush the Diggers' camps.

Q9. What radical belief did the Diggers hold about private property and the earth?

Q10. Why did wealthy Parliamentarians like Oliver Cromwell violently crush the Diggers?

It is time to synthesize your understanding of the ideological and physical battles of the English Civil War.

Q11. Lesson Reflection: Was the English Civil War a true revolution that gave power to the people, or just a transfer of power from the King to wealthy Parliamentarians? Use the IDEA framework to structure your response.

Q12. How did the English Civil War and the execution of Charles I change the balance of power?

L6: Who controlled Britain? The Economic Shift

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the major economic changes of the 17th century.
- ☐ Analyze the impact of colonial wealth on social structures.

Do Now: Previous Knowledge

1. What political belief held that kings were chosen directly by God and possessed absolute power?
2. What was the name of the illegal tax on coastal (and later inland) towns revived by Charles I during his Eleven Years' Tyranny?
3. What was the name of Parliament's disciplined, professional military force created during the Civil War?
4. Who served as the commander of the New Model Army and later became 'Lord Protector' of England?
5. On what date was King Charles I executed outside the Banqueting House in London?

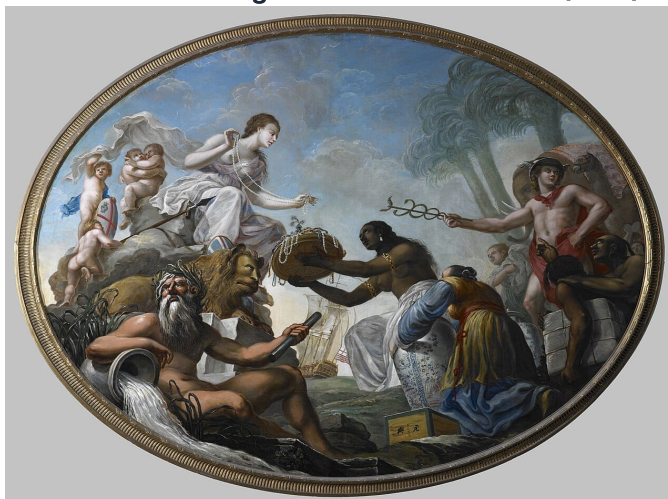
Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):

Mercantilism | Navigation Acts (1651) | Fiscal-Military State | Bank of England (1694) | Royal African Company (RAC) | Consumer Revolution

Teacher Model / Pupil Sentence:

The East Offering its Riches to Britannia (1778)



Notice how Britannia sits elevated, while figures representing Asia, Africa, and India offer her their goods. This painting was placed on the ceiling of the East India Company's headquarters, literally looking down on the directors as they made decisions about global trade.

A ceiling painting by Spiridione Roma (1778), originally commissioned for the Revenue Committee Room at East India House. It is an allegorical painting showing Britannia's wealth, receiving jewels, spices, and silk from Asia,

Africa, and India. It highlights the ideology and wealth of Britain's empire.

Q1 How useful is this painting as evidence of Britain's global power and ideology in 1778?

Q2 Study Source E (The Great Seal of the Commonwealth of England). How does the imagery on this 1651 seal reflect the political upheaval following the execution of Charles I?

Look at Source B. What did the design of the 1651 Great Seal signal about Britain's new priorities compared to the previous 600 years?

Q3 Look at Source E. What did the design of the 1651 Great Seal signal about Britain's new priorities compared to the previous 600 years?

By the 1700s, the geography of wealth in Britain had fundamentally changed. London was no longer just the seat of the King; it had become the beating heart of a new global financial empire. The River Thames was choked with a forest of wooden ship masts from the East India Company and transatlantic slave ships. The wealth generated by this massive maritime trade built institutions like the Bank of England and the Royal Exchange, shifting power from the monarchy to the merchant class.

Source A



The Royal Exchange, London (1644)

Q4. Based on Source A, how did the visual appearance of London change as it became a global financial hub?

Look closely at the **1651 Great Seal of England**, created after the King's execution:

- **No Royal Crown or Arms:** For 600 years, the Great Seal bore the face of the ruling King or Queen on a horse. In 1651, the King's face was completely erased.
- **The House of Commons Side:** Shows hundreds of MPs sitting in Parliament with the motto: *"In the First Year of Freedom by God's Blessing Restored."*
- **The Map Side:** Shows a detailed map of England, Ireland, and naval ships sailing in the Atlantic, emphasizing maritime power and imperial expansion over royal bloodlines.

Source E



The Great Seal of the Commonwealth of England (1651)

Q5. Look at Source E. What did the design of the 1651 Great Seal signal about Britain's new priorities compared to the previous 600 years?

In 1660, after Cromwell died, Britain restored the monarchy, inviting Charles I's son, **Charles II**, back to the throne (**The Restoration**). But did things really go back to how they were?

Interpretation 1: The Political View (Christopher Hill, 1961)

"The Execution of Charles I permanently smashed the Divine Right of Kings. Though Charles II returned in 1660, no British monarch would ever again rule without Parliament's consent or impose taxes without their vote."

Interpretation 2: The Imperial/Economic View (Eric Williams, 1944)

"The true victor of the Civil War was neither the King nor Parliament; it was the Atlantic mercantile class. The sugar of Barbados and the tobacco of Virginia created a political force so wealthy that no King or Parliament could ever again govern Britain without prioritizing imperial trade."

Think-Pair-Share: Q6 How do Interpretation 1 and Interpretation 2 differ in identifying the true 'winner' of the Civil War?

1. My Thoughts (Think)	2. Partner's Thoughts (Pair)

Q7. Explain how the 'Financial Revolution' (like the Bank of England) helped Britain build a modern empire.

L7: What were the mechanics of the Transatlantic Slave Trade?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the Triangular Trade and the middle passage.
- ☐ Evaluate the economic legacy of slavery on Britain.

Do Now: Previous Knowledge

1. What is a 'joint-stock company'?
2. What cash crop saved the Jamestown colony from economic failure?
3. Who won the English Civil War (1642-1651)?

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:

Triangular Trade | Middle Passage | Barracoon | Chattel Slavery | Plantation Complex | Branding

Power, Governance & Warfare

Economy, Trade & Society

The Transatlantic Slave Trade was not simply a case of European ships arriving and kidnapping people from the beach. It was a massive, highly organized global business that relied on complex treaties and alliances. Powerful African empires, such as the Dahomey and the Asante, grew wealthy by launching military campaigns against rival inland groups, taking prisoners of war. These captives were marched for weeks to the coast and sold to European merchants in exchange for manufactured goods like brass, textiles, and, crucially, European firearms. The European merchants would lock the enslaved Africans in brutally crowded, disease-ridden coastal fortresses known as 'barracoons' or 'castles' (like Cape Coast Castle in modern-day Ghana) for months, waiting for slave ships to arrive. The trade enriched both European merchants and coastal African elites, while completely devastating the interior of the African continent.

This global business operated in three distinct steps, known as the **Triangular Trade**:

1. **Outward Passage (Europe to Africa):** Ships left Europe carrying manufactured goods (textiles, rum, and firearms).
2. **The Middle Passage (Africa to the Americas):** The manufactured goods were traded for enslaved Africans, who were transported across the Atlantic in brutal conditions.
3. **The Return Passage (Americas to Europe):** Enslaved labor produced raw cash crops (sugar, cotton, tobacco), which were shipped back to Europe to be sold at massive profits.

Source A



Cape Coast Castle, a European slave fort on the Gold Coast

Q1. How did powerful African empires like the Dahomey acquire people to sell into slavery?

Q2. What goods did European merchants trade in exchange for enslaved people?

Q3. Study Source A. What does the heavy fortification of Cape Coast Castle tell us about the nature of the slave trade?

Q4. Drawing Task: Draw a flowchart mapping the 'Triangular Trade' between Europe, Africa, and the Americas, labeling the goods traded at each point.

Between 1500 and 1867, over 12.5 million African men, women, and children were kidnapped, forced onto ships, and transported across the Atlantic Ocean. Over 3 million were carried on British ships.

Interactive Trade Map

Exports from Europe (Bristol, Liverpool, London)

- **Manufactured Firearms:** Cheap muskets and gunpowder used to fuel regional African wars.
- **Textiles and Cloth:** Mass-produced British cotton and wool items.
- **Alcohol:** Spirits such as rum and brandy used as trade currency.
- **Metal Goods:** Iron bars, brass pans, and manillas (copper bracelets).

Exports from West Africa

- **Enslaved Human Beings:** Men, women, and children captured in warfare or raids.
- **Gold Dust:** Extracted from the Gold Coast and heavily sought after by European merchants.

- **Ivory:** Elephant tusks traded as a luxury good.
- **Spices:** Exotic items like malagueta pepper (Guinea pepper).

Exports from The Americas

- **Raw Sugar & Molasses:** The most lucrative cash crop, grown in the brutal Caribbean plantations.
- **Tobacco:** Grown extensively in the colonies of Virginia and Maryland.
- **Raw Cotton:** Crucial raw material shipped to British textile mills during the Industrial Revolution.
- **Coffee and Cocoa:** Luxury consumables destined for European coffeehouses.

The Mechanics of "Chattel" Slavery

Unlike historical forms of bondage, Atlantic slavery was **chattel slavery**. Enslaved people were defined by law as personal property, bought, sold, mortgaged, and inherited like cattle or furniture.

- **The Middle Passage:** A nightmare voyage lasting 6 to 10 weeks across the Atlantic. Humans were crammed below decks in spaces smaller than coffins. Between 15% and 20% of enslaved people died before reaching the Americas.
- **Plantation Economics:** Caribbean sugar production was brutal industrial labor. Enslaved workers were forced to cut sugarcane with machetes under burning heat for 18 hours a day, faced disease, and suffered severe punishment from white overseers.

Source B

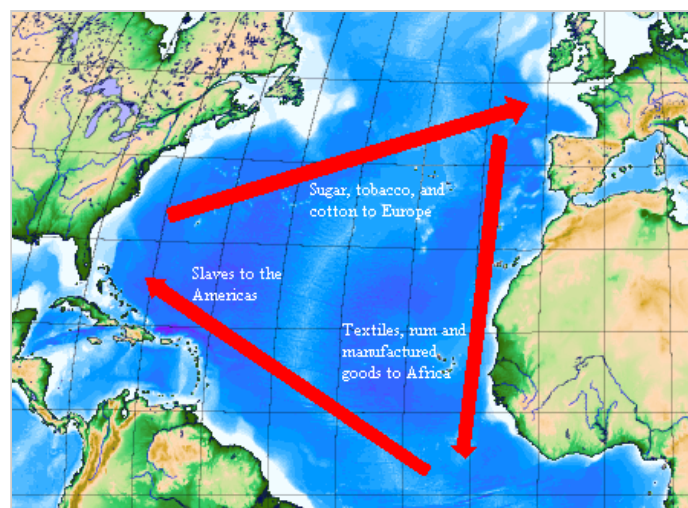


Diagram of the Triangular Trade

Q5. Based on Source B (the flowchart), what specific goods were exchanged for enslaved Africans in West Africa?

The experience of an enslaved African depended heavily on where the slave ship landed. In the Caribbean (like Jamaica and Barbados), the primary crop was sugar. Sugar cultivation was incredibly brutal, dangerous, and physically destroying labor. Many Caribbean plantations were owned by 'absentee landlords'—rich white men who lived in luxury in London and never even visited their estates, leaving brutal overseers in charge. Because profits were so high, these overseers calculated that it was cheaper to literally work enslaved people to death (the 'death camp' model) and simply buy replacements from Africa. Life expectancy upon arriving on a sugar plantation was often less than seven years. By contrast, in the North American colony of Virginia, the primary crop was tobacco. Tobacco required less intensive daily physical destruction than sugar. Furthermore, a different climate and slightly better diet meant that, by the 1700s, the enslaved population in Virginia became 'self-sustaining' (growing through childbirth rather than relying entirely on importing new people from Africa). While Virginia was still a brutal system of chattel slavery, the lethal intensity of the Caribbean sugar machine was unmatched.

Source C



A Cuban sugar plantation, showing the scale of the operation

Q6. What is an 'absentee landlord'?

Q7. Why was the Caribbean sugar system often described as a 'death camp' model?

Q8. Study Source C. Why do you think absentee landlords back in London were able to ignore the brutality shown in illustrations like this?

To understand how slavery shaped modern Britain, conduct a real-world historical investigation using the Centre for the Study of the Legacies of British Slavery at University College London (UCL).

STUDENT RESEARCH INSTRUCTIONS

1. Open your web browser and navigate to the **UCL Legacies of British Slavery Database** (ucl.ac.uk/lbs).
2. Click on "**Search the Database**" and select "**Commercial & Financial Legacies**" or search by **Geographic Location** (e.g., Bristol, Liverpool, London).

[Visit ucl.ac.uk/lbs] → [Search Your Region] → [Trace Local Wealth]



INVESTIGATION WORKSHEET

- **Task A:** Identify one individual/family who claimed compensation in 1833. Record their name, the number of enslaved people they 'owned', and the payout received.
- **Task B:** Investigate what happened to that wealth. Was it invested in local British buildings, railways, artwork, or bank stocks?
- **Task C:** Write a 150-word summary evaluating how your local area directly benefited from Atlantic plantation economies.

Q9. UCL Research Task Worksheet: Summarize the core findings of your local investigation into the legacies of slavery. Use the IDEA framework to structure your response.

Let's review the mechanics of the Transatlantic Slave Trade.

It is time to synthesize your understanding of the mechanics of the Transatlantic slave trade.

Q10. Lesson Reflection: How did the reality of the Transatlantic Slave Trade and the brutal 'death camp' model of the Caribbean sugar plantations challenge the idea that 18th-century Britain was a 'modern', enlightened, and civilized society? Use the IDEA framework to structure your response.

Q11. How did the Triangular Trade directly enrich British port cities?

L8: How did enslaved Africans resist the Transatlantic Slave Trade?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Analyze primary sources from formerly enslaved Africans.
- ☐ Investigate the Jamaican Maroon Wars.

Do Now: Previous Knowledge

1. What were the three legs of the Triangular Trade?
2. What was a 'barracoon'?
3. Why was sugar known as a 'killer crop'?

Vocabulary Check

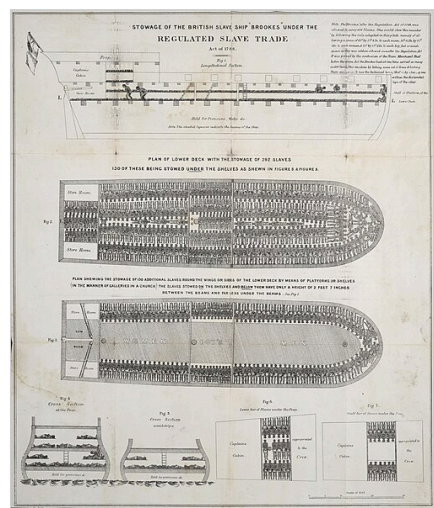
Spot the Deliberate Error: Read the statement below. One historical fact or vocabulary concept has been deliberately falsified. Underline the error and explain the accurate historical reality below:

Spectrum of Resistance | Maroons | Covert Resistance | Stono Rebellion (1739) | Obeah | Abolitionism

"Historians agree that enslaved Africans rarely engaged in resistance, accepting plantation life passively until white British politicians invented Abolitionism without any Black involvement."

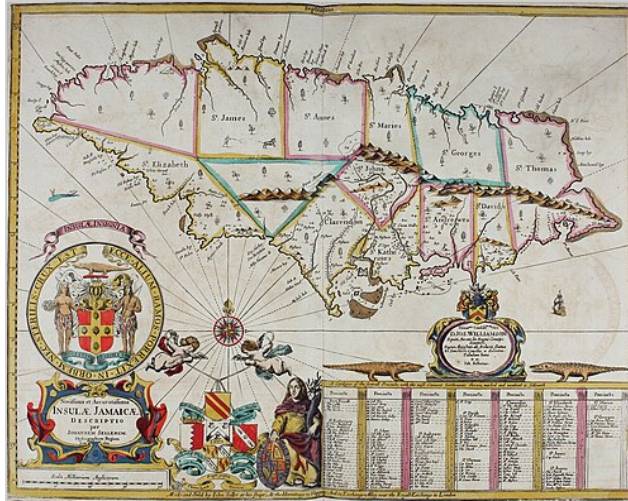
Teacher Model / Historical Correction:

Source A



The infamous 1788 abolitionist poster showing a cross-section of the slave ship *Brookes*. It vividly exposed the horrific overcrowding and inhumane conditions enslaved Africans endured during the brutal Middle Passage, galvanizing public outrage in Britain.

Source B



A 1775 map of Jamaica by Thomas Jefferys. The island's rugged, mountainous interior provided sanctuary for Maroon communities—escaped enslaved Africans who waged a highly successful, decades-long guerrilla war against British colonial forces.

High in the mist-shrouded Blue Mountains of eastern Jamaica, an English army patrol crept through the dense rainforest in 1734. Suddenly, the trees themselves seemed to come alive.

Men and women dressed in camouflage woven from forest foliage descended upon the soldiers. The English troops were routed without ever seeing the main body of their enemy. Leading this guerrilla force was a woman whom British colonial officials called a "rebel witch," but whom her people knew as **Queen Nanny**.

Born in the Gold Coast (modern-day Ghana) around 1686, Nanny was kidnapped, enslaved, and brought to Jamaica. She escaped from a sugar plantation into the rugged interior, joining communities of formerly enslaved people known as **Maroons** (derived from the Spanish *cimarrón*, meaning "wild" or "untamed").

Nanny was an extraordinary military strategist. She established **Nanny Town**, a fortified, self-sufficient mountain sanctuary where freed Africans grew crops, maintained African cultural traditions, and launched lightning raids to free enslaved workers from nearby British sugar plantations.

For over a decade, British forces tried and failed to conquer Nanny Town. By 1739, the British Crown was forced to do something unthinkable: **sign a peace treaty with former slaves**, recognizing their freedom and granting them 1,500 acres of autonomous land in Jamaica.

Queen Nanny's story shatters a persistent historical myth: that enslaved Africans were passive victims who waited silently for white European abolitionists to free them. From the decks of slave ships to the sugar fields of the Caribbean, African resistance was continuous, sophisticated, and relentless.

Q1. Study Source B. How did the geography of Jamaica shown in the map help the Maroons wage a successful guerrilla war against the British?

Q2. How does the story of Queen Nanny challenge the traditional historical narrative about the abolition of slavery?

Q3. Drawing Task: Sketch a visual representation of Queen Nanny's hidden mountain stronghold and how it helped the Maroons resist the British.

Resistance was not always an armed uprising. Enslaved Africans fought back against a dehumanizing system in dozens of calculated ways every single day.

Hidden Sabotage

- Slowing down work pace on the fields to damage profits
- Breaking tools and expensive plantation machinery on purpose
- Feigning illness, injury, or ignorance to avoid forced labor
- Secretly preserving African languages, religions, and music
- Poisoning overseers' food or livestock using local plants

Armed & Direct Defiance

- Armed rebellion, assassinations, and plantation burning
- Shipboard revolts and mutinies during the Middle Passage
- **Marronage:** Escaping permanently to form free, fortified towns
- Self-emancipation (purchasing own freedom) and publishing memoirs
- Political activism and speaking tours in European capitals

Q4. Give one example of covert resistance and explain why an enslaved person might choose it over overt resistance.

To truly understand the experience of the Transatlantic Slave Trade, we must read the words of those who survived it.

Source A: Olaudah Equiano Recounts the Terror of the Ship's Hold (1789)

"The closeness of the place, and the heat of the climate, added to the number in the ship, which was so crowded that each had scarcely room to turn himself, almost suffocated us. This produced copious perspirations, so that the air soon became unfit for respiration, from a variety of loathsome smells, and brought on a sickness among the slaves, of which many died... The shrieks of the women, and the groans of the dying, rendered the whole a scene of horror almost inconceivable."

— **Olaudah Equiano**, *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano* (1789).

Source B: Equiano Describes Shipboard Revolts

"One day, when we had a smooth sea and moderate wind, two of my wearied countrymen, who were chained together (I was near them at the time), preferring death to such a life of misery, somehow made through the nettings, and jumped into the sea: immediately another quite dejected fellow, who, on account of his illness, was suffered to be out of irons, also followed their example... I believe many more would very soon have done the same, if they had not been prevented by the ship's crew, who were instantly alarmed."

— **Olaudah Equiano**, *The Interesting Narrative* (1789).

Source C: A Jamaican Overseer's Diary Recording Everyday Sabotage (1771)

"May 14: The slaves again delayed the grinding of the cane... claim the main waterwheel spindle is broken by accident, but I suspect it was done maliciously by the mill boiler. May 19: Found three cows dead in the lower pasture, poisoned with nightshade root. The Negroes deny all knowledge, but there is a spirit of sullen defiance among them."

— **Adapted from the diary of Thomas Thistlewood**, a Jamaican sugar plantation overseer.



Portrait of Olaudah Equiano (1789)

Q5. Inferring Motive (Source A): Why did jumping overboard represent a powerful act of resistance for enslaved Africans, even though it resulted in death?

Q6. Evaluating Significance (Equiano's Portrait & Source A): Why was Equiano's autobiography so historically revolutionary when published in London in 1789?

While hidden, day-to-day resistance was constant, sometimes it exploded into outright war. In September 1739, a literate enslaved man named Jemmy led a coordinated armed uprising in South Carolina known as the Stono Rebellion. The rebels seized weapons, marched under banners that read 'Liberty!', and beat drums to rally others as they marched south toward Spanish Florida (specifically the settlement of St. Augustine), where they were promised freedom. Although the rebellion was eventually crushed by the brutal South Carolina militia, it terrified the planter class. It proved that enslaved Africans could organize militarily and were actively fighting for their freedom, leading the panicked British colonists to pass the draconian 1740 Negro Act, which severely restricted enslaved people's ability to assemble, grow their own food, or learn to read.

Source D



Map of the Stono Rebellion route (1739)

Q7. Based on the geography in Source D, why did the Stono Rebellion march specifically head South towards St. Augustine rather than inland, and what does this reveal about international rivalries?

Q8 Match the aspects of the Stono Rebellion to their correct historical descriptions.

The Cause		The Spanish promised freedom in Florida to any enslaved person who escaped.
The Event		The British planters passed the brutal Negro Act of 1740, heavily restricting movement, assembly, and education.
The Consequence		A group of 20 enslaved Africans broke into a store, armed themselves, and marched south beating drums.

For a long time, the traditional history taught in British schools focused heavily on the 'White Savior Narrative'. This narrative argues that slavery was abolished in 1833 almost entirely because of moral, upper-class white politicians in Parliament—most famously, William Wilberforce. Wilberforce did indeed dedicate decades of his life to a tireless parliamentary campaign to ban the trade, using horrific evidence like the Brookes ship diagram to shock the British public. However, modern historians (like Eric Williams) strongly challenge this 'white savior' focus. They argue that Wilberforce's moral campaign only succeeded because of two deeper reasons. First, economics: by the 1800s, the sugar plantations were becoming less profitable as the world industrialized. Second, grassroots resistance: massive, terrifying armed rebellions by enslaved people (like the Haitian Revolution and the Jamaican Baptist War) made slavery too dangerous and expensive for the British to maintain. In this view, enslaved people essentially forced the British government's hand; Wilberforce simply passed the law in London.

Source F



Portrait of William Wilberforce, a British politician and abolitionist

Think-Pair-Share: Q9 Compare Source F with the story of Queen Nanny. Why is it dangerous to rely solely on portraits like Source C when trying to understand how and why the slave trade was eventually abolished?

1. My Thoughts (Think)	2. Partner's Thoughts (Pair)

Think-Pair-Share: Q10 What is the 'White Savior Narrative' in the context of the slave trade?

1. My Thoughts (Think)	2. Partner's Thoughts (Pair)

Q11. According to modern historians like Eric Williams, what were the *true* underlying reasons slavery ended?

Q12. Study Source F (Portrait of William Wilberforce, a British politician and abolitionist). Why were portraits like this important for the abolitionist movement in the late 18th century?

It is time to synthesize your understanding of how enslaved Africans resisted the Transatlantic Slave Trade.

Q13. Lesson Reflection: Why is it historically inaccurate and damaging to claim that the abolition of the slave trade was purely the result of benevolent white politicians like William Wilberforce? Use the IDEA framework to structure your response.

Source E



18th-century botanical illustration of the Cassava root

SIDE QUEST: OBEAH AND BOTANICAL WARFARE

When we think of resistance to slavery, we often picture armed rebellions or people running away. But there was a terrifying, silent, and highly intelligent form of psychological and chemical resistance happening right under the enslavers' noses. Enslaved people brought deep spiritual and botanical knowledge from West Africa, which evolved in the Caribbean into a belief system known as Obeah. Obeah practitioners (often women) were deeply respected healers within the enslaved community, possessing expert knowledge of local toxic plants. Because enslaved women often worked in the plantation houses cooking the enslavers' food, they occasionally used this botanical mastery to slowly, undetectably poison brutal overseers and plantation owners. Enslavers lived in a state of constant, paranoid terror of Obeah, passing strict laws to criminalize it.

Q14. Study Source E. Why might enslaved people's deep botanical knowledge of plants like cassava have been a more terrifying form of resistance for plantation owners than an armed rebellion?

Q15. Why might psychological and chemical resistance have been just as effective as armed rebellion?

Q16. Explain how the Jamaican Maroons successfully resisted British control.

L9: How 'modern' was Britain by 1750? (Synthesis & Assessment)

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Define what historians mean by a 'modern' state in the context of 18th-century Europe.
- ☐ Synthesise domestic social realities with imperial/commercial expansion across the period 1450–1750.
- ☐ Construct a high-level, structured final essay evaluating the extent of Britain's 'modernity' by 1750.

Do Now: Previous Knowledge

1. What was the primary function of the 1607 Jamestown Fort design?
2. Why did Oliver Cromwell execute King Charles I in 1649?
3. What was the strategic advantage of the Jamaican Maroons' location?
4. What motivated the creation of the Royal African Company?

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Select *THREE* terms that share a close historical connection. Identify which *ONE* remaining term is the 'Odd One Out' in this lesson, and explain your historical reasoning:

Constitutional Monarchy | Rotten Borough | The Bloody Code | Gin Craze | Urbanisation | Enlightenment

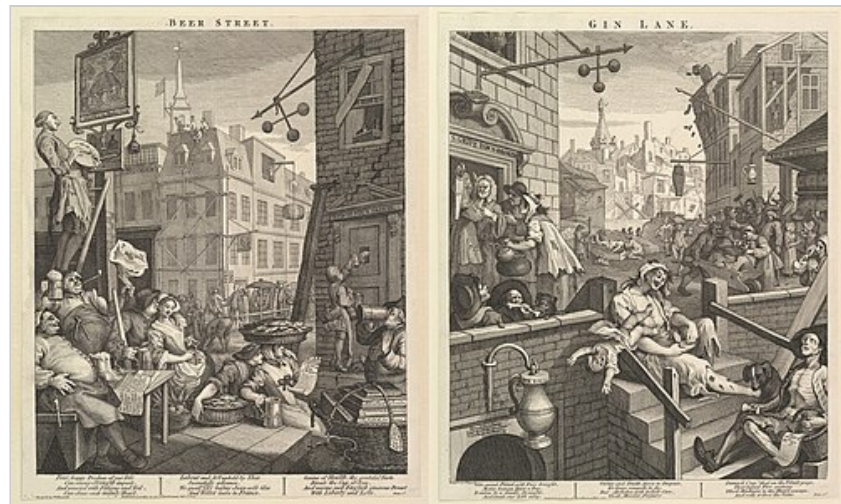
Teacher Model / Pupil Reasoning:

Source A



A 1632 painting by Claude de Jongh showing London Bridge. By the 18th century, the River Thames was choked with global merchant shipping, reflecting London's explosion in population and its status as the center of a global empire.

Source B



William Hogarth's 1751 engraving 'Gin Lane' depicts the horrifying social decay, poverty, and alcohol addiction rampant in 18th-century London slums. Hogarth created this print as a direct piece of propaganda to support the Gin Act, seeking to reduce the mass consumption of cheap spirits.

In October 1750, a French aristocrat named Pierre-Jean Grosley stood on London Bridge and looked out over the River Thames.

To his right, he saw a forest of wooden masts belonging to over 1,000 merchant ships. These vessels had arrived from Canton, Calcutta, Barbados, and Virginia, packed with tea, silk, raw sugar, and tobacco. Nearby stood the **Bank of England** and the **Royal Exchange**, where stockbrokers traded paper credit, fire insurance, and national debt using complex mathematics that stunned the rest of Europe. London was the financial beating heart of a global, capitalist empire.

Then Grosley walked off the bridge and turned into the narrow alleys of St. Giles.

Within five minutes, the scent of expensive Indian spices was replaced by the stench of open sewage, rotting garbage, and cheap gin. He passed desperate mothers pouring raw grain spirit down the throats of crying infants to quiet them. In these slums, 50% of children died before the age of five. Medical care still relied on bloodletting with leeches, public executions at Tyburn Tree drew crowds of 30,000 howling spectators, and women had zero legal rights, remaining the legal property of their husbands.

Grosley was left with a baffling paradox: **Was Britain in 1750 a hyper-modern global superpower, or a brutal, unequal medieval society wearing a wig?**

As Britain grew incredibly wealthy from the transatlantic slave trade and the East India Company, it developed a powerful new self-image. The British elite did not view themselves as brutal conquerors; instead, they believed they were bringing civilization and order to the world. Art from this period heavily utilized classical mythology to portray Britannia as a righteous, glorious figure receiving the willing submission and wealth of the globe.

Source A



The East Offering its Riches to Britannia (1778)

Q1. Study Source A. How does this painting glorify the British Empire while masking the brutal realities of colonization?

To answer our key enquiry, we must step back and examine the transformation of Britain over the entire 300-year span of this unit.

1450: FEUDAL & ISOLATED

- Absolute Monarchy • Subsistence Agriculture • Regional Trade • No Colonies

↓ [300 YEARS OF TRANSFORMATION] ↓

1750: THE PRE-INDUSTRIAL STATE

✓ PRO-MODERN ELEMENTS

- Constitutional Monarchy
- Global Commercial Empire
- Financial System (Bank of England)
- Early Infrastructure (Turnpikes)

✗ UN-MODERN REALITIES

- Disenfranchisement (<5% vote)
- Brutal 'Bloody Code'
- Empire built on slavery
- Pre-Industrial Technology

Explore the two sides of the argument below to decide if Britain was truly 'modern':

**Argument A: Global Wealth
(Modern)**

**Argument B: Domestic Reality
(Un-Modern)**

Britain Was Superbly "Modern" by 1750

- **Constitutional Balance:** The Civil War (1642–1651) and Glorious Revolution (1688) permanently ended absolute royal tyranny. King George II governed *through* Parliament.
- **The Financial Revolution:** Founded in 1694, the **Bank of England** invented the modern system of national debt and paper banknotes, allowing Britain to out-finance rivals.
- **Global Economic Integration:** British citizens drank tea from China, sweetened with Caribbean sugar, smoked Virginia tobacco, and wore Bengal cotton.
- **Transport Infrastructure:** By 1750, over 1,500 miles of **Turnpike Roads** (paved toll roads) connected London to provincial towns, cutting travel times in half.

Britain Remained Profoundly "Un-Modern" by 1750

- **Political Inequality:** Parliament was controlled entirely by wealthy aristocrats. Less than **5% of the male population** had the right to vote. Rotten boroughs bought and sold elections.
- **The "Bloody Code":** The legal system terrorized criminals. Over 200 offenses carried the death penalty, including stealing a sheep or picking a pocket.
- **An Empire Built on Slavery:** Britain's economic "modernity" was completely reliant on the barbaric machinery of the Transatlantic Slave Trade.
- **Pre-Industrial Technology:** In 1750, 80% of the population still lived in rural villages. Factories did not yet exist. Power came from human muscles, horses, wind, and water.

Q2. Drawing Task: Draw a single symbol or logo that you feel best represents the state of 18th-century Britain (e.g., a combination of a bank, a ship, and chains).

Source B



The Royal Exchange, London (1644)

Q3. Based on Source B (Weighing the Evidence toggle tabs), identify one piece of political evidence that proves Britain was modern, and one piece of political evidence proving it was un-modern.

Analyze these two contrasting contemporary accounts written in the mid-18th century.

Source C: From a German Visitor's Diary (Pehr Kalm, 1748)

"In England, even the common country people live well and wear clean linen. Their homes are built of brick or stone, not clay. Every village hath its turnpike road, and goods are transported with incredible speed by wagon and barge. The law protects the poorest peasant from the nobleman; no man may be imprisoned without trial. In commerce and freedom of speech, Britain is two hundred years ahead of the continent."

Think-Pair-Share: Q4 Reconciling Contradictions: How can Source C and Source D offer completely opposite views of Britain in the late 1740s/1750s without either author necessarily lying?

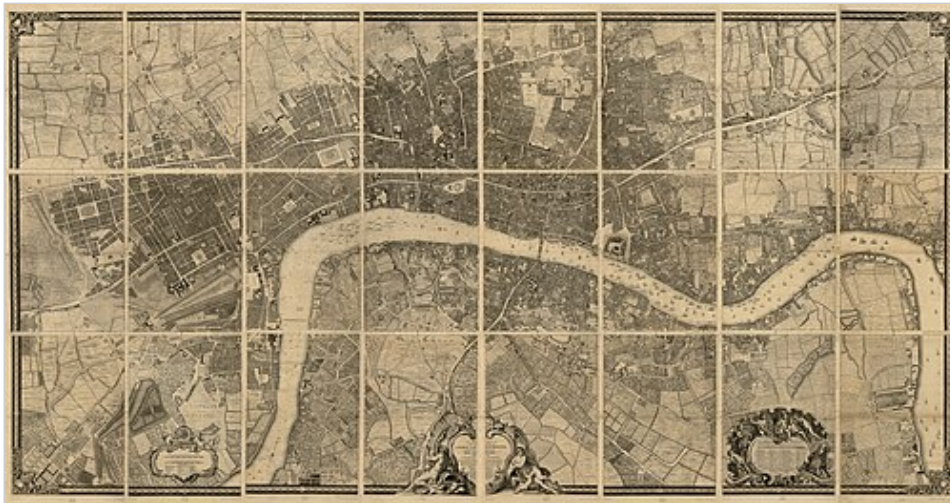
1. My Thoughts (Think)	2. Partner's Thoughts (Pair)

Source D: From a London Magistrate's Report on Crime (Henry Fielding, 1751)

"The streets of this great city are daily rendered unsafe by bands of armed footpads and cutpurses... Multitudes of wretches perish annually of sheer cold and gin-poisoning in the cellars of St. Giles, unheeded by any magistrate. Our prisons are foul dens of typhus fever where accused men rot for months before trial. We boast of our liberties, yet our poor live in a state of barbarism lower than the beasts."

Q5. Synthesis Challenge: Combine the insights from Sources C and D with your knowledge of the Atlantic Slave Trade to write a nuanced 3-sentence summary of British society in 1750.

Source E



John Rocque's Map of London (1746)

Q6. How does the density and infrastructure of London shown in Source E (1746) provide hard evidence for a 'modernizing' Britain compared to the agricultural society you studied in 1450?

Historian Perspective A: Prof. Roy Porter (1990)

"By 1750, Britain was already the world's first modern, secular, consumer society. It possessed a constitutional government, a vibrant free press, unmatched global trade, and an enterprising middle class that valued property, science, and progress."

Historian Perspective B: Prof. J.C.D. Clark (1985)

"18th-century Britain was not a 'modern' nation; it was an Ancien Régime—a deeply traditional, aristocratic, and religious society dominated by the Anglican Church, wealthy landowners, and a hereditary monarchy. Most people's daily lives were governed by ancient custom, local isolated community, and rural poverty."

To conclude this entire 1450–1750 unit, you will write a 4-paragraph final essay answering the enquiry question: **"How 'modern' was Britain by 1750?"**

Q7 Assessment Planner: Structure your argument before you write your final essay.

Point (Your claim)	Evidence (Historical facts)	Explanation (Why this matters)

Q8. Map these historical realities onto the spectrum below to plan your argument.



Source F: An authentic drawing of 'Mudlarks' scavenging in the freezing River Thames, showing the extreme poverty that still haunted London.

By 1750, wealthy Londoners were discussing Enlightenment science in elegant coffee houses. But for the desperately poor, this 'modern' city was a brutal slum. Driven by plummeting grain prices, a horrifying epidemic known as the Gin Craze gripped the capital. Gin was cheaper than beer and safer to drink than the filthy Thames water, devastating working-class slums with addiction, crime, and starvation. Meanwhile, desperate children known as 'Mudlarks' spent their days wading thigh-deep in the freezing, sewage-filled mud of the River Thames just to scavenge for dropped scraps of coal or copper to sell for a penny. For the urban poor, 1750 did not feel 'modern'—it felt lethal.

Q9. Study Source F. How does the existence of 'Mudlarks' challenge the idea that 1750 London was entirely prosperous and modern?

Q10. How 'modern' was Britain by 1750?

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